

bbtkv3: An Open-Source Suite for Timing Measurement and Analysis with the Black Box ToolKit v3

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Experimental psychologists require sub-millisecond accuracy in measuring stimulus presentation and participant response times. The Black Box ToolKit (BBTK) is a widely used hardware solution for such measurements. One limitation is that the software provided along the BBTK by the vendor is specific for Windows. We developed a cross-platform suite of command line tools and a library designed to interface with the BBTK v3. These tools included serial port detection, sensor threshold adjustment and automated event capture. Additionally, it includes an interactive shell for manual device control and a statistical analysis tool that computes event durations, jitter, and latencies from captured data. Built in Go, the suite is distributed as self-contained binaries for Windows, macOS, and Linux. The source code and a library for embedding BBTK control in Go applications are available under the GPL-3.0 licence at <https://github.com/chrplr/bbtkv3>.

Keywords: timing accuracy, stimulus presentation, response time, Black Box ToolKit, open-source software, behavioral research methods

Introduction

Precise timing is a cornerstone of experimental psychology. Variations in stimulus presentation or response recording can introduce noise or even systematic biases that confound experimental results (Plant et al., 2004). While modern computers are capable of high performance, their multi-tasking operating systems and complex hardware architectures (e.g., display buffering, USB polling) often introduce unpredictable latencies.

The Black Box ToolKit (BBTK) was developed to address these challenges by providing an external hardware reference for timing measurements. It acts as a digital oscilloscope and signal generator, capable of capturing activity on light and sound sensors, as well as TTL signals, with sub-millisecond precision. The typical experimental setup involves three components: a) A **stimulation device** (e.g., a computer) running the experimental paradigm; b) The **BBTK hardware** with input sensors (photodiodes, microphones) and TTL inputs/outputs connected to the stimulation device; c) A **host computer** (which may be the same as the stimulation device with our software) driving the BBTK and recording the data (see Figure 1).

The BBTK communicates with the host computer via a se-

rial protocol described in the BBTK API guide (Plant, 2016). The **bbtkv3** software suite that we developed encapsulates this protocol into a set of command-line tools and a high-level library. Designed to be cross-platform (while the vendor's software is specific to Windows), it is easy to install, and can be integrated into automated testing workflows. One of its advantages is that the event capture can run simultaneously on the same computer that runs the stimulation.

Software Suite Components

The **bbtkv3** suite consists of several modular CLI tools, summarized in Table 1. This modularity allows researchers to use only the components they need or to chain them together in scripts.

Core Functionality

Calibration and Monitoring

Proper calibration of sensor thresholds is important for reliable data. The **bbtk-adjust-thresholds** and **bbtk-input-check** tools provide researchers with feedback on sensor activity, allowing them to set sensitivity levels that distinguish stimuli from background noise or ambient light.

Event Capture and Analysis

The primary uses of **bbtkv3** is the objective measurement of latencies. For example, a researcher might want to

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Figure 1

Principle of operation: The BBTK acts as an independent observer of the stimulation device's outputs. Here a optical sensor detects when the illumination of the screen reaches a certain threshold. Here, the 'bbtk-capture' program that drives the BBTK device during events capture runs on the stimulation computer.

Table 1

The bbtv3 toolset

Tool	Description
bbtk-detect-port	Scans serial ports to locate the connected BBTK.
bbtk-capture	Captures events for a specified duration and exports them to CSV and binary formats.
bbtk-input-check	Provides a live stream of sensor states for real-time validation.
bbtk-adjust-thresholds	Interactive menu for sensor sensitivity calibration.
bbtk-get-thresholds	Reads current sensor thresholds from the device.
bbtk-set-thresholds	Writes new threshold values to the device.
bbtk-event-marking	Configures the device for real-time event marking.
events-stats	Performs statistical analysis on captured timing data.
ibbtk	An interactive shell providing access to all device functions.

measure the delay between a TTL trigger sent by the experimental software and the actual appearance of a stimulus on the screen (detected by a photodiode).

The `bbtk-capture` tool automates this process. It can be launched for a specific duration, during which it records all transitions on the 12 input lines (4 optical, 2 microphone, 2 TTL, and 4 keypad inputs). All the user has to do is enter the command shown on Listing 1 below.

```
# Detect port and capture for 60 seconds
BBTK_PORT=$(bbtk-detect-port)
bbtk-capture -d 60
# analyse measurements
events-stats bbtv3-capture-001.events.csv
```

Listing 1: Example capture command

At the end of the event capture, data are downloaded from

the BBTK onto the host PC and saved for further analyses. Among the saved files, a `.dat` file contains the raw output of the BBTK and an `.events.csv` file consists of a table with three columns: `type`, `onset`, `duration`, where `type` indicates the sensor (`Opto1`, `Mic1`, `TTLin1`, ...

This CSV file can easily be imported in a spreadsheet, a Python or R notebook for inspection. Nevertheless, we provide a command-line tool, `events-stats`, which can immediately outputs descriptive statistics and ASCII histograms about the timing data. It computes a) **event durations**, that is, the distribution of how long each sensor remained active; b) **inter-onset intervals**, the timing regularity of successive events on a given sensor; c) **paired-event onset differences**, the latency between a reference event (e.g., TTL trigger) and a target event (e.g., photodiode detection). Figure 2 shows an example of the output from a simple stimulation program (1

frame on — 2 frames off) ran on a Raspberry 4.

Interactive Usage

An interactive tool, `ibbtk`, allows the user to “manually” send commands. This is useful for debugging and exploration of the device’s capabilities. It maintains a persistent connection, avoiding the overhead of re-opening the serial port for each command.

Library

Furthermore, because the entire suite is built upon a modular Go package, developers can easily integrate BBTK control directly into their own Go-based experimental or analysis software, e.g., (Pallier, 2026).

Implementation and Availability

`bbtkv3` is written in Go, leveraging the `go.bug.st/serial` library for cross-platform serial communication. By using Go, we are able to provide self-contained, statically linked binaries that require no runtime environment (like Python or Java) nor external DLLs.

The software is available for Windows, macOS, and Linux, and Intel and arm architectures for each operating system. Source code and pre-compiled binaries are hosted on GitHub (<https://github.com/chrplr/bbtkv3>) under the GNU General Public Licence v3.

Author Contributions

C.P. conceptualized the software, designed the library, and implemented the tools. Claude Sonnet and Gemini 2.5 were used in the final phase of the project, to clean some bugs and to develop the event-stats tool. Consistent with current editorial norms (Springer Nature, 2023). C.P. takes full responsibility for the content of the work.

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ADD LEFTHEADER COMMAND

=== Duration Statistics (ms) ===

Type	N	Min	P5	P25	P50	P75	P95	Max	Range	P95-P05	Mean	SD
Opto1	1000	36.5	37.0	37.0	37.2	37.2	37.5	37.8	1.2	0.5	37.2	0.20

```

[ 36.500, 36.625) ms : 2
[ 36.625, 36.750) ms : 0
[ 36.750, 36.875) ms : 28 **
[ 36.875, 37.000) ms : 0
[ 37.000, 37.125) ms : 283 *****
[ 37.125, 37.250) ms : 0
[ 37.250, 37.375) ms : 449 *****
[ 37.375, 37.500) ms : 0
[ 37.500, 37.625) ms : 229 *****
[ 37.625, 37.750) ms : 9

```

=== Inter-Onset Interval / Jitter Statistics (ms) ===

Type	N	Min	P5	P25	P50	P75	P95	Max	Range	P95-P05	Mean	SD
Opto1	999	49.2	49.8	49.8	50.0	50.0	50.2	50.5	1.2	0.5	50.0	0.19

```

[ 49.250, 49.375) ms : 1
[ 49.375, 49.500) ms : 0
[ 49.500, 49.625) ms : 13 *
[ 49.625, 49.750) ms : 0
[ 49.750, 49.875) ms : 270 *****
[ 49.875, 50.000) ms : 0
[ 50.000, 50.125) ms : 481 *****
[ 50.125, 50.250) ms : 0
[ 50.250, 50.375) ms : 227 *****
[ 50.375, 50.500) ms : 7

```

=== Paired-Event Onset Differences: TTLin1 > Opto1 (ms) ===

Type	N	Min	P5	P25	P50	P75	P95	Max	Range	P95-P05	Mean	SD
TTLin1>Opto1	1000	31.0	39.0	39.0	39.2	39.2	39.5	39.8	8.8	0.5	39.2	0.32

```

[ 31.000, 31.875) ms : 1
[ 31.875, 32.750) ms : 0
[ 32.750, 33.625) ms : 0
[ 33.625, 34.500) ms : 0
[ 34.500, 35.375) ms : 0
[ 35.375, 36.250) ms : 0
[ 36.250, 37.125) ms : 0
[ 37.125, 38.000) ms : 0
[ 38.000, 38.875) ms : 22
[ 38.875, 39.750) ms : 977 *****

```

Figure 2

Print out of `events-stats` from a capture taken while the stimulation computer presented 1000 cycles of 1 frame-on, 2 frames-off. The display monitor refresh rate was fixed at 60Hz. The first section show the detected duration of the on-frames; note that the BBTk adds 20ms to the duration measures because smoothing was set on Opto1). The second section reports on the SOA between successive on-frames. The last section display statistics about the delay between Opto1 activation and a TTL signal that was sent just after the call to display flip. Note the 2-frames delay.